I will never forget the day of June 6th, 2023. I was about five years into my career as a software engineer and nearly two years into my job at Mission Lane, a fintech company that extends unsecured lines of credit to people that traditional banks often turn away. That morning, I was one of roughly half the company's employees who were laid off in order to put more resources toward building its own proprietary large language model. It was the first time in my career that I had ever been laid off; what's more, it really made me question what my purpose in life was supposed to be. I had only ever known being a software engineer in my career. That experience has fundamentally shaped a belief I brought into this course, which is, as automation eliminates jobs, many people will lose not only their income but their sense of purpose, and our government is not prepared to help them find it again.

I am incredibly grateful that I have been able to continue my career as a software engineer, and even more grateful to be pursuing a Master's in Artificial Intelligence here at the University of St. Thomas. I also recognize how fortunate I was, despite being laid off at the time nearly 3 years ago. I had technical skills, a career to return to, and the opportunity to go back to school. Many people whose jobs are automated or sent overseas will have none of those things. AI labs like Anthropic, OpenAI, xAI, Google, Meta, and many companies in China are continually pushing the boundaries of what is possible with artificial intelligence, and I doubt that pace will slow anytime soon. At the same time, I see little evidence that our government (namely, Congress) has a plan to help the people it leaves behind, either by replacing their income or by helping them find a new sense of purpose.

This course gave me the chance to test that belief, and the first place I tested it was our Week 3 lecture on Aristotle. Aristotle described the goal of human life as *eudaimonia*, which our lecture defined as building "a prosperous life, which is blissful, successful," and directed "towards the best or ultimate satisfaction" (Thero et al., 2022, as cited in Keaveny & Benzel, 2026c). According to the lecture, the happiest life requires three things: money, pleasures, and being well thought of. I expected this to challenge my belief, since a job is not on that list; instead, it reinforced it. In our society, a job is not only how people earn money, but is also one of the main ways people earn the respect of others. Losing a job takes away two of Aristotle's three requirements at once, which is money and being well thought of.

The connection between work and respect is not new. In 1776, Adam Smith observed that a working man of his time "would be ashamed to appear in public without a linen shirt," because lacking one would suggest a poverty "which, it is presumed, nobody can well fall into without extreme bad conduct" (Smith, 1776/2000, bk. V, ch. II). Nearly 250 years later, I felt that same presumption. When I was laid off, the paycheck was not the only thing I lost. I also lost the daily connection of working alongside talented people, and I had to carry the stigma that comes with being laid off: that I had somehow failed at my job. Losing that sense of being well thought of hurt as much as losing the income. Programs like unemployment insurance can temporarily replace some of the money, but nothing our government offers replaces those losses.

A common response to concerns like mine is that AI will create more jobs than it replaces, just as past technologies eventually did. I understand that argument, but it assumes that any job is as good as the one that was lost. The Ludwig Institute for Shared Economic Prosperity challenges that assumption with what it calls the *True Rate of Unemployment*, which counts not only people without work, but also people who want full-time work and cannot find it, and people who earn less than a living wage. As of August 2026, that rate was 24.3%, compared with an official unemployment rate of 4.1% (Ludwig Institute for Shared Economic Prosperity, 2026). Simply put, nearly one in four Americans is either out of work or working without being able to support themselves. Our Week 2 lecture showed me that AI is adding to this problem, not solving it. The slides reminded us to "remember the workers behind the data work" (Keaveny & Benzel, 2026b), and in preparing for our debate on synthetic data, I learned that OpenAI relied on contractors in Kenya who were paid less than $2 an hour to label graphic and disturbing content (Perrigo, 2023). Those are real jobs that AI created, but they are not the kind of work that gives a person financial security, let alone a sense of purpose. If the new jobs created by AI are low-paid, invisible, and sometimes traumatic, then the promise that AI will create more jobs does nothing to answer my concern. It only changes the kind of loss people experience.

My own layoff was not an isolated case. Our class debates showed me how far AI is reaching into work that has always required human judgment. In our debate on replacing Omaha's traffic court with an AI kiosk, the proposal would have removed the judge entirely. A judge can reduce a fine, set up a payment plan, or dismiss a ticket because a driver fixed the

taillight. And as our Week 6 lecture quoted, software "lacks a core feature that makes humans unique: judgment" (Cerullo, 2023, as cited in Keaveny & Benzel, 2026e). Yet in the entire debate, we argued about efficiency, bias, and due process, and no one asked what would happen to the judge, in addition to the pipeline of lawyers who would one day potentially seek filling the position.

Our debate on neural network triage in the emergency room revealed a subtler loss. The nurse keeps the job, but under pressure, a nurse can easily become a rubber stamp for the machine's ranking, keeping the title while losing the judgment that gave the work meaning. Our course asks, "Should a machine do it now?" (Keaveny & Benzel, 2026e), but the question is always about the machine, never about the person who did the work before. Our government has failed to answer this question, and unfortunately continues to display a lack of comprehending the question altogether. In our Week 4 lecture on tech accountability, we discussed the multi-state lawsuit alleging that Meta designed Facebook and Instagram to addict children, which ended in a settlement of up to $18 billion (Jones et al., 2026), a penalty that amounts to little more than a slap on the wrist for a company of Meta's size. As the lecture noted, these cases "take time;" for example, the Philip Morris trial lasted from 1999 to 2006 (Keaveny & Benzel, 2026d). If our government struggles to hold technology companies accountable for the harm they do to their users, I have little confidence it is prepared for the harm they do to the workers they replace.

So, did my belief ultimately change? No, but it did sharpen. I came into this course believing that automation would leave many people without both an income and a sense of purpose, and that our government was not prepared to help them. After testing that belief against Aristotle, Adam Smith, and our class debates, I still hold it, but I understand it more precisely now. The problem is not only that jobs are disappearing. It is that our society ties money, respect, and purpose to work, while our government's response treats job loss as a problem of income alone, and even then only temporarily. Our Week 1 lecture asked, "When does the human cost become too high for the building of a better machine?" (Keaveny & Benzel, 2026a). For roughly half of my colleagues at Mission Lane, that question was answered on June 6th, 2023. As AI continues to advance, I believe the hardest question our government must face is not only how to

replace a paycheck, but how to help people find purpose and be well thought of when there is less work to go around. Until it begins to answer that question, I expect many more people to experience what I did.

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